ERA 9

The Slave South

1848 – 1860

Cotton · the enslaved experience · resistance & community

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did cotton and slavery shape Southern society—and how did the enslaved resist?

KEY TERMS

Cotton is King · planter aristocracy · the domestic slave trade · Nat Turner · resistance & community

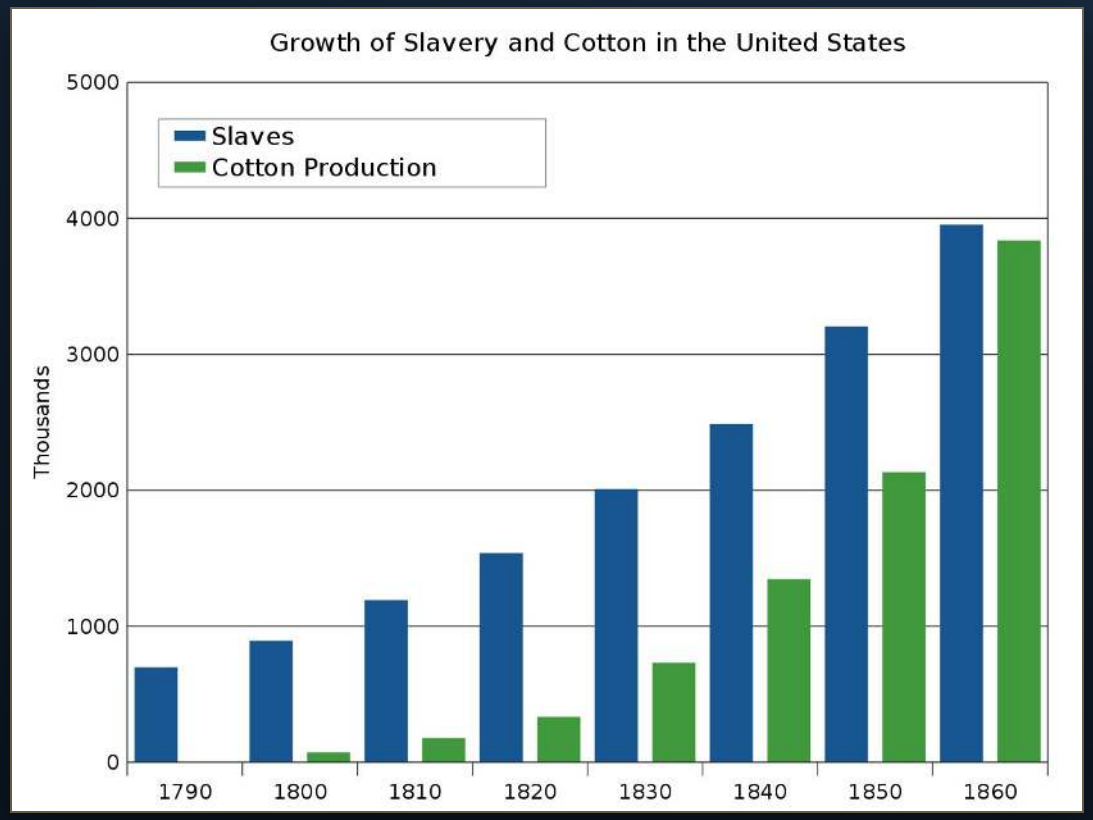
ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 4.12–4.13 · AMSCO Ch. 4.12–4.13

AN ECONOMY BUILT ON COTTON

The Slave South

'Cotton Is King'



- By 1860, **cotton** made up more than half of all U.S. exports.
- It was the foundation of the Southern economy—and enriched Northern mills too.
- As Senator Hammond boasted, **'Cotton is King.'**

Southern Society

A small planter elite dominated a society of millions

GROUP	SHARE OF THE SOUTH	ROLE
Planter Aristocracy	A tiny elite (<2,000 families)	Owned 100+ enslaved people; ran politics & culture
Yeoman Farmers	Most white Southerners	Small farms; few or no enslaved people
Poor Whites	A large underclass	Landless—yet still defended slavery
Enslaved People	~4 million by 1860	Did the labor that powered King Cotton

The Planter Aristocracy

- Fewer than 2,000 families owned 100 or more enslaved people.
- This tiny elite dominated Southern politics and culture.
- Planters embraced **paternalism**—casting themselves as benevolent 'fathers.'



SECTION

Defending Slavery

From 'Necessary Evil' to 'Positive Good'

EARLY

A Necessary Evil

Founders often called slavery a regrettable inheritance.

→

COTTON

A Profitable System

The cotton boom made slavery immensely lucrative.

→

DEFENSE

A 'Positive Good'

Southerners now defended slavery as beneficial to all.

SECTION

The Enslaved Experience

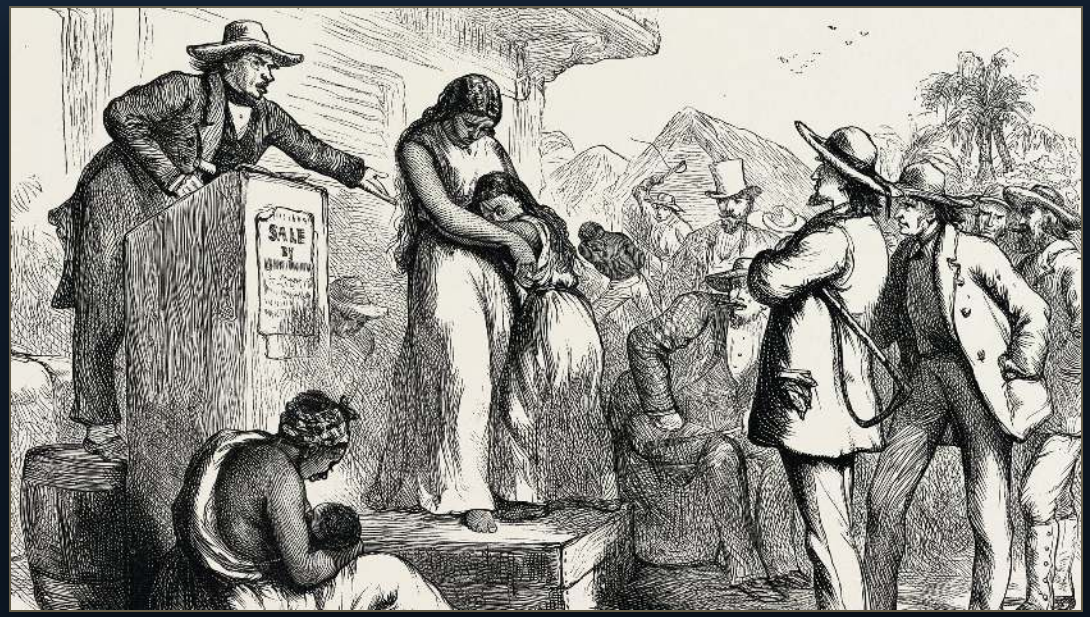
Life Under Slavery



- Enslaved people endured brutal labor under paid **overseers**.
- They lived in crude, dirt-floor cabins with few possessions.
- **Slave codes** denied them legal rights and basic freedoms.

The Domestic Slave Trade

- After the Atlantic trade ended in 1808, an **internal slave trade** exploded.
- More than 2 million people were sold from the Upper South to the Deep South.
- Families were torn apart—loved ones sold 'down the river.'



SECTION

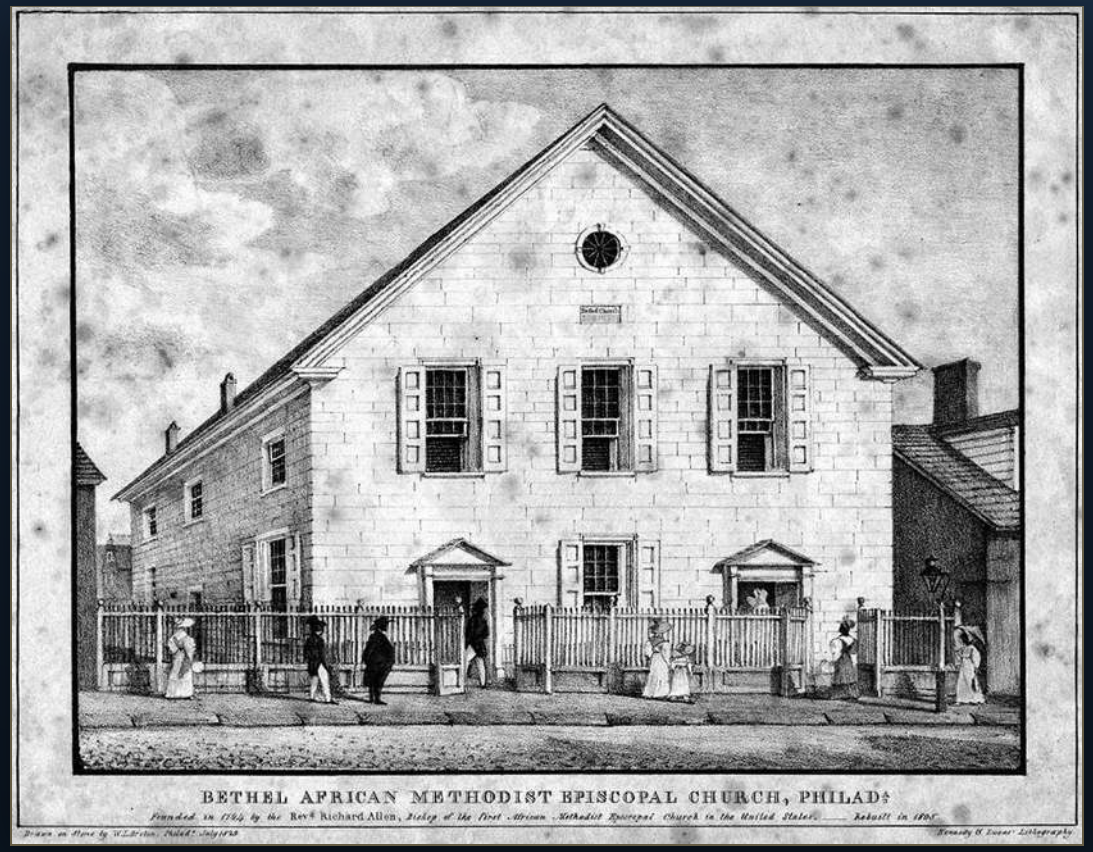
Resistance & Community

Resistance & Rebellion



- **Denmark Vesey** planned a major uprising in 1822.
- In 1831, **Nat Turner** led a rebellion that killed about 60 white Virginians.
- The South responded with brutal crackdowns and tighter **slave codes**.

Faith, Family & Community



- Enslaved people built strong **community** bonds to survive.
- Independent Black churches like the **AME** Church took root.
- Faith, family, and culture became powerful forms of resistance.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Slave South

1. **'Cotton is King'**—slavery was the foundation of the Southern economy, ruled by a tiny **planter aristocracy**.
2. The **domestic slave trade** forced millions into the Deep South, tearing families apart.
3. Enslaved people resisted through rebellion (**Nat Turner**, **Denmark Vesey**) and by building enduring faith and **community**.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Slave South

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the demand for **cotton** shaped the economy and society of the antebellum South.

COMPARISON

Compare the different ways—overt and covert—that enslaved people **resisted** their bondage.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did Southern arguments about slavery shift from a **'necessary evil'** to a **'positive good'**—and why?

Up next — **Class 25: A House Dividing** (the Compromise of 1850 & Bleeding Kansas)